

Adjectival fragments and clausal ellipsis in English and German: Experimental evidence for island sensitivity under clausal ellipsis favouring an in-situ silent structure approach

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Abstract

The paper reports the results of four experiments on adjectival fragments and sluicing in English and German. The primary purpose of these experiments was to test the predictions of the *Syntactic Question Approach* (SQA) to clausal ellipsis. This analysis adopts a conservative view of the syntax of clausal ellipsis, as it denies that remnants must undergo A'-movement to escape the ellipsis site, denies that ellipsis repairs island violations, and permits ellipsis sites to be syntactically anisomorphic to their antecedents. The SQA maintains instead that observed ellipsis-specific restrictions arise from constraints governing ellipsis recoverability. However, like most sententialist theories of ellipsis, the development of the SQA was informed by informally collected acceptability judgment data, which are known to often be underinformative and unreliable for the purpose of analyzing ellipsis. By conducting experiments on adjectival fragments, we test various configurations in which, depending on the analysis, the remnant of ellipsis may or may not have undergone left-branch extraction (LBE) from within the ellipsis site. We find that, of the several sententialist analyses we consider, our results are most compatible with (a version of) the SQA, which therefore provides new empirical support for this approach. Specifically, we find evidence that island-violating LBE is not repaired by ellipsis, that LBE can be evaded by using an anisomorphic ellipsis site, and that non-*wh* remnants do not undergo ellipsis-driven A'-movement. In addition, by comparing English and German, we find evidence for two strategies for recovering ellipsis sites: one that only compares the meanings of ellipsis site and its antecedent, and one which compares their syntactic structures. Which strategy is employed appears to depend on whether or not the ellipsis remnant displays particular morphosyntactic cues.

Keywords: adjectival fragments, clausal ellipsis, experimental syntax, island sensitivity, English, German, left-branch extraction

1. Introduction

This paper addresses three foundational (groups of) questions from the mainstream generative literature on ellipsis, which adopts a *silent structure* approach to this phenomenon (Ross 1969; Merchant 2001):¹

¹ Regarding (1a), influential defenses of clausal ellipsis involving unselective deletion include Merchant 2001, 2004, Lasnik 2001, Takahashi & Fox 2005, and van Craenenbroeck 2010, whereas proposals to treat ellipsis as involving selective selection include Reich 2007, Ott & Struckmeier 2018, Griffiths 2019, Stigliano 2022, and Griffiths et al. 2023. Regarding (1b), Lasnik (2001), Yoshida et al. (2012), Fox & Lasnik (2003), and Takahashi & Fox (2005) defend the notion that an ellipsis site must be isomorphic to its antecedent, whereas Merchant (2004), Abels (2011), Barros et al. (2014), Griffiths (2019), Rudin (2019), and Anand et al. (2025) argue that (constrained) anisomorphism is permitted. Regarding (1c), Merchant (2001, 2004, 2008), Lasnik (2001), Rottman & Yoshida (2013), and Potter (2017) support the notion that certain grammatical violations—most prominently island violations and other A'-movement dependencies—may be *repaired* under ellipsis, insofar as the offending structure is rendered unpronounced. Competing approaches question the existence or scope of ellipsis repair effects, reanalyzing them in terms of independent constraints on movement, ellipsis licensing, or discourse coherence (see, e.g., Abels 2011; Barros et al. 2014; Griffiths 2019).

(1) a. **The application of deletion**

Does ellipsis always involve the unselective deletion of an entire phrase, entailing that remnants of ellipsis must undergo movement to escape ellipsis, or can ellipsis apply selectively within a phrase, thus obviating the need for ellipsis-driven movement?

b. **Syntactic isomorphism**

Must elided phrases be syntactically isomorphic to their antecedents? If not, how much structural divergence is tolerated? Are there environments in which an isomorphic ellipsis site is required?

c. **Ellipsis repair**

Do certain grammatical operations that yield ungrammaticality in XP cease yielding ungrammaticality when ellipsis applies to XP? If so, which operations?

We address these questions by reporting and interpreting the results of four acceptability judgment experiments – two on English and two on German – that investigate the interaction of clausal ellipsis and left-branch extraction. We argue that the experiments' results uniquely support the *Syntactic Question Approach* (SQA) to clausal ellipsis outlined by Griffiths (2019) and Griffiths et al. (2023). Because the SQA makes several key claims regarding the questions in (1), we therefore obtain new evidence for these claims. These claims are:

- (2) a. Ellipsis applies selectively to XP, which entails that an ellipsis remnant YP contained in XP undergoes A'-movement only if it would do so anyway in XP's non-elliptical counterpart.
- b. An ellipsis site can be syntactically *anisomorphic* (not isomorphic) to its antecedent, provided that independent constraints are satisfied.
- c. Island-violating A'-movement is not repaired under ellipsis.

By providing new evidence for this in-situ approach, we undermine its competitors, in particular the prevailing *Move-and-Delete Approach* (MDA; Merchant 2001, 2004), which is based on the stipulation that ellipsis applies unselectively, and the influential proposal that ellipsis can repair island-violating A'-movement (Lasnik 2001, Merchant 2001, 2008, Fox & Lasnik 2003, van Craenenbroeck 2010, Rottman & Yoshida 2013, Yoshida et al. 2015, Potter 2017, Yoshida et al. 2019).

Specifically, our experimental results support a 'supplemented' version of the SQA. The supplement consists in the acknowledgement of the existence of two strategies for licensing ellipsis, one of which involves utilizing a licenser without linguistic form to license ellipsis (henceforth, the *semantic* strategy), and one which involves utilizing a licenser with linguistic form to license ellipsis (henceforth, the *syntactic* strategy). The hearer employs the syntactic strategy only when the remnant of ellipsis exhibits a morphosyntactic feature that is associated with a specific syntactic position with an ellipsis site. Otherwise, the hearer employs the semantic strategy. Precisely how this idea, which is inspired by a similar proposal called *cue-based retrieval* that is couched in the nonsententialist ellipsis framework (Nykiel et al. 2022; cf. Cortés Rodríguez 2025), supplements the existing claims that comprise the SQA will be discussed in §2.3.

The paper proceeds as follows: §0 offers a detailed overview of the relevant theoretical background on clausal ellipsis, with a focus on the tenets of the SQA. §0 also provides a critical assessment of previous experimental research on island-sensitivity under clausal ellipsis. §0 presents the practical and logistical details common to all of the experiments comprising the series. §§4–6 present the English experiments, whereas §§6–7 present the German experiments. A general discussion and conclusion are provided in §9.

2. Background

2.1 Formal licensing, ellipsis identity, and accommodated antecedents

As a silent structure approach, the SQA upholds the core tenet that ellipsis is the suppression of the phonological realization of syntactic terminal nodes within a designated phrase. The SQA follows the common practice of invoking the existence of a syntactic feature *E*, which encodes instructions for both PF and LF concerning the derivation and interpretation of clausal ellipsis (Merchant 2001, 2004). For clausal ellipsis, this feature is hosted by the Force head in English. *E* is interpreted by PF as an Optimality-Theoretic constraint that penalizes Vocabulary Insertion in *E*'s sphere of influence; see (3). The SQA assumes that there exists an ellipsis-independent PF-constraint that favors Vocabulary Insertion into the terminal nodes that comprise focused phrases (4).² Because fulfilling (4) is more important than fulfilling (3), a focused phrase *YP* within an *E*-marked *XP* will always be pronounced: *YP* is the ellipsis *remnant* (see (6), where elided material is enclosed in chevrons). Because remnants need not undergo ellipsis-specific movement to escape the ellipsis site, the SQA is therefore classed as an *in-situ* analysis (for others, see Abe & Tancredi 2013, Abe 2015, 2016, Ott & Struckmeier 2018, Stigliano 2022, among others). It therefore contrasts with the MDA developed by Merchant (2001, 2004), in which a remnant of ellipsis *YP* always undergoes movement to escape an unselective deletion process that applies to its container *XP*.

- (3) *Ellipsis*: Let *XP* be a phrase whose head bears the ellipsis feature *E*. Assign a penalty for each terminal node in *XP* into which a Vocabulary Item is inserted.³
- (4) *Focus*: Let *YP* be a focused phrase.⁴ Assign a penalty for each terminal node in *YP* into which no Vocabulary Item is inserted.
- (5) *Focus* outranks *Ellipsis*.
- (6) a. Sally sold something. God knows [_{XP} <*X*_[E]> [_{YP} what]₁ <she sold *t*₁>].
b. What d'you think Sally sold? I reckon [_{XP} <*X*_[E] she sold> [_{YP} her watch]].

The SQA was primarily developed as an attempt to reconcile two well-motivated yet seemingly incompatible recent claims about the nature of the identity condition on clausal ellipsis. The first claim is that clausal ellipsis identity must – at least in part – be calculated over phrase markers (probably LFs) as opposed to merely unstructured propositions (as assumed by Merchant 2001).⁵ This claim is motivated by the observation that, even when an elliptical clause *E*

² For current purposes, it suffices to define *YP* as a *focused phrase* if it coincides with the maximal extent of focus-feature percolation from within it. For more precise descriptions, see Selkirk's (1995) FOC-marking or Griffiths' (2019) extension of Cable's Q-particle theory of pied-piping.

³ For the purposes of (3) and (4), inserting the null morpheme $\emptyset$ still counts as Vocabulary Insertion.

⁴ Note that non-at-issue discourse particles can such as German *wohl* and *denn* (Ott & Struckmeier 2018) and English *even* (Griffiths et al. 2023: fn12) can optionally avoid clausal ellipsis, meaning that such items optionally fall under the remit of (4).

⁵ Evidence that clausal ellipsis identity cannot be reduced to mere propositional (truth-conditional) equivalence comes from several domains. First, ellipsis is sensitive to argument-structure mismatches even when antecedent and ellipsis site are truth-conditionally equivalent (Grimshaw 1990, Merchant 2008, Barros 2014, Thoms 2016). Second, ellipsis tracks scope and binding relations that are standardly represented at LF, rather than surface meaning alone (Fox 2000, Takahashi & Fox 2005). Third, restrictions on ellipsis under voice alternations and related diatheses indicate sensitivity to syntactic structure beyond propositional content (Merchant 2013, Kertz 2013, Rudin 2019). Together, these findings motivate an identity condition stated over structured linguistic representations, plausibly phrase markers at LF, rather than over unstructured propositions.

and its antecedent A are truth-conditionally equivalent, E is judged as unacceptable if its argument structure differs from A's (Grimshaw 1990, Merchant 2008, Barros 2014, Thoms 2016). This suggests that E and A must have similar argument structures for ellipsis to be licensed in E. If this is correct, then the identity condition must be stated over structured linguistic objects, in which information about argument structure is encoded (Fox 2000, Takahashi & Fox 2005, Barros et al. 2015, Griffiths 2019).

The second claim is that clausal ellipsis is licensed by a question-like information state Q in the set of *Questions Under Discussion* (QUD, Roberts 2012), rather than by the explicitly uttered antecedent clause (Reich 2002, 2004; Krifka 2006; Barros 2014a; Weir 2014; Barros & Kotek 2019; Griffiths 2026). According to this claim, an elliptic clause that immediately follows an explicitly uttered interrogative or assertion is licensed by the Q invoked by that interrogative or assertion.

Because Qs are information states rather than linguistic objects, analyses that propose that the antecedent for all instances of clausal ellipsis is the topmost Q in the QUD (i.e., the *maxQUD*) are committed to saying that ellipsis identity is calculated over unstructured meanings. Such proposals are therefore incompatible with the first claim discussed above, namely that clausal ellipsis identity must be stated over phrase markers.

As mentioned already, the SQA is an attempt to reconcile these two claims. To do this, the SQA stipulates not that clausal ellipsis can only be licensed by the *maxQUD* but rather that clausal ellipsis can only be licensed by an immediately preceding syntactic question, where *syntactic question* means 'a linguistic object with question-like semantics **and** interrogative syntax'; see (7).

(7) Ellipsis can only be licensed by a discourse-proximate syntactic question.

Stipulating (7) reconciles the two differing viewpoints outlined above, as it explains why clausal ellipsis is particularly sensitive to Qs yet allows one to entertain an identity condition stated over LFs.

If the antecedent clause is an interrogative, as in (8), then (7) is trivially satisfied, and therefore an assessment of whether the identity condition on clausal ellipsis is satisfied can proceed straightforwardly. Although the SQA maintains that identity is calculated over phrase markers, it is not committed to any specific proposal. Therefore, for the purposes of illustration, we endorse here the condition recently offered for sluicing by Anand et al. (2025), which is presented in (9).⁶ As (10) shows, this condition is satisfied in (8B), as lexical and structural identity obtains between the elided nodes *she* and *hire* and their counterparts in the antecedent clause.

- (8) A: Who will Sally hire?
B: <She will hire> Lucy.

- (9) *Syntactic Identity Condition* (adapted from Anand et al. 2025:360)
a. An E-marked ForceP may be elided only if the lowest head in its extended projection projects or selects an argument domain XP that meets the condition in (9b).

⁶ Because recovering the identity of an ellipsis site is a pragmatic process, (9) should be understood as a formal restriction on pragmatic reasoning. Intuitive pragmatic constraints such as "mismatches must be minimal" and "mismatches must be motivated" also hold (see Fox 1999, 2000; Thoms 2015): these constraints are particularly important for restricting the extent to which mismatch is permitted above the argumental domains of an elliptic/deaccented clause and its antecedent.

- b. There is a phrase YP in the discourse context, such that for each pair of heads $\langle a, b \rangle$ in $\mathcal{H}$, the set of heads targeted for elision in XP, there is a pair of heads $\langle a', b' \rangle$ in YP such that:
 - i. Lexical identity: a and a' are tokens of the same lexical item, b and b' are tokens of the same lexical item, and
 - ii. Structural identity: the path in XP between a and b is the same as the path in YP between a' and b' .

(10) For (8A): [who will Sally <will> [_{AD} <Sally> hire <who>]]
 For (8B): [Sally will [_{AD} <Sally> hire Lucy]]
 (AD = argument domain and <XP> = a copy of movement)

Now consider the dialogue in (11). Here, (11A) is not an interrogative, meaning that (7) is not satisfied, yet ellipsis is judged as acceptable.

- (11) A: Sally will hire someone.
 B: Yeah, <Sally will hire> Lucy.

To account for this, the SQA appeals to Fox's (1999) proposal that, when the identity condition cannot be satisfied using the antecedent that is explicitly provided, hearers can attempt to accommodate a viable antecedent, using the non-elliptical material in the antecedent and elliptical clause as building material. This process, which generates implicit linguistic objects and which is independently motivated for ellipsis licensing, is called *antecedent accommodation* (see Fox 1999, 2000; Thoms 2015; Griffiths 2019; Griffiths et al. 2023; see Barros 2014a; Weir 2014; Kotek & Barros 2018; Barros & Kotek 2019 for weaker conceptions).

To satisfy (7), an antecedent must therefore be accommodated for (11). Roughly speaking, this procedure is constrained such that the argument domain of the accommodated antecedent must be syntactically constructed using non-elliptical linguistic material in the proximate discourse context. To ensure that the accommodated antecedent can be an interrogative that has the elliptical response as its answer, a *wh*-phrase is needed. This is obtained by substituting the remnant of ellipsis XP with a *wh*-phrase W of the same syntactic category, where $\llbracket W \rrbracket$ must equal $\llbracket XP \rrbracket_f$ (for further technical details, see Griffiths et al. 2023, especially its appended Supplementary Materials). The resulting interrogative in (12iii) then takes on the role of 'licensor' for assessing whether the identity condition in (9) is satisfied for (11B). Ellipsis is judged as acceptable in (11B) because the identity condition is indeed satisfied once the accommodated interrogative in (12iii) is taken as the true licensor.

- (12) *Antecedent accommodation for (11)*
- i. *Lucy* in (11B) is substituted for *which candidate* (or any other suitable *wh*-phrase)
 - ii. Material used from (11A): *Sally, will, hire*
 - iii. Accommodated antecedent: *which candidate will Sally hire?*

According to the SQA then, the impression that the maxQUD is the ellipsis licensor – which motivates QUD-approaches to ellipsis licensing – arises from the simple fact that any discourse involving a sluice or fragment answer will involve an explicitly uttered or accommodated antecedent syntactic question, and the maxQUD is invoked from, and is therefore identical in meaning to, this explicit or accommodated syntactic question.

Before moving on, let us briefly demonstrate that the SQA has predictive power. When comparing (13) and (14), one observes that both the DP and P remnants are permitted in (13), but only a PP remnant is permitted in (14). This difference appears to be connected to the

difference in antecedent-type: an alternative question in (13) versus a declarative assertion in (14).

- (13) A: Is the best hiding place under or in the bed?
 a. B: In the bed.
 b. B: In.
- (14) A: The best hiding place is under the bed.
 a. B: No, { in the bed / in the attic }.
 b. B: * No, in. [Intended: the best hiding place is in the bed]
 c. B: # No, the car. [Intended: the best hiding place is under the car]

Given that SQA affords interrogatives a key role in licensing clausal ellipsis, it is uniquely placed to capture these data. Because the stipulation in (7) is trivially satisfied in (13), the alternative question can fulfil the role of antecedent for the purposes of calculating identity. For both (13a) and (13b), the identity condition is satisfied, as (15) shows (where *best hiding place* is abbreviated as BHP).

- (15) For (13A): [is the BHP <is> [AD <the BHP> [[[under or in] the bed]]]]?
 For (13a-b): [the BHP is [AD <the BHP> [[[in] the bed]]]]?

In the case of (14), an interrogative antecedent must be accommodated in order to satisfy the stipulation in (7). Although a grammatical *wh*-interrogative can be accommodated for (14a), resulting in the identity condition being satisfied (see (16)), none can be accommodated for (14b) or (14c). Accommodation for (14b) fails because the *wh*-substitution mechanism described above cannot be utilized, as there are no *wh*-counterparts to adpositions. In the case of (14c), while the ellipsis remnant *the car* can be substituted for *what*, *which place*, or some similar *wh*-phrase, a grammatical *wh*-question (with the relevant intended interpretation) cannot be formed using this *wh*-phrase, as (17) shows. Consequently, accommodation fails here, too. The fragments in (14b-c) are therefore judged as unacceptable because no viable (accommodated) antecedents are available from which the ellipsis that generates them can be licensed.

- (16) *accommodated ant:* [where is the BHP <is> [AD <the BHP> <where>]
fragment: [the BHP is [AD <the BHP> in the attic]

- (17) * [{What / which place}]₁ is the best hiding place under *t*₁?

To summarize: because the SQA is an in-situ approach to ellipsis, it makes no recourse to ellipsis-specific movement. Instead, it adopts the default position that movement occurs (or not) just as it would if ellipsis did not apply. In terms of ellipsis recoverability, the sole innovation of the SQA is the stipulation in (7), namely that clausal ellipsis can only be licensed by an interrogative. Aside from this, the SQA adopts the ascendant position that ellipsis recoverability is primarily pragmatic, but that the pragmatic reasoning involved – which can involve accommodating a new antecedent (following Fox 1999 and many others) – is restricted by the need for some of the elided heads that comprise the elliptical clause to have lexically and structurally parallel counterparts in the antecedent (Fox 2000, Takahashi & Fox 2005, Merchant 2008, Barros et al. 2014, Thoms 2016, Ranero 2021, Griffiths 2019) (for the purposes of illustration, we adopted Anand et al.'s 2025 syntactic identity condition).

Because it allows for antecedent accommodation and endorses Anand et al.'s identity condition in (9) (or something similar to it, e.g., Ranero's 2021 alternative), the SQA assumes

by default that ellipsis sites can be structurally anisomorphic to their antecedent, provided that (9) is satisfied. This acceptance of the existence of anisomorphic ellipsis sites, for which abundant evidence exists (Merchant 2001, Abels 2011, Barros et al. 2014, Thoms 2016, Griffiths 2019, Rudin 2019, Anand et al. 2021, Cortés Rodríguez 2022, 2025, Cortés Rodríguez & Griffiths 2024a, b) plays a key role in how the SQA explains the variable island (in)sensitivity of clausal ellipsis, the topic to which we now turn.

2.2 Island (in)sensitivity and the SQA

In both (18a) and (18b), the correlate (boldfaced) is island-bound. This yields unacceptability in (18a) but not (18b), meaning that (18a) is island-sensitive, whereas (18b) is not.

- (18) a. *Abby is happy [_{ISLAND} because **Ben** won], but I don't know who Chuck is.
 b. Abby is happy [_{ISLAND} because **someone** won], but I don't know who.

Some researchers have suggested that ellipsis can 'repair' the ungrammaticality incurred by island-crossing A'-movement. A repair approach to (18) would propose that that *who* in (18b) crosses an island-boundary, but because the boundary is contained in the ellipsis site (see (19)), no island penalty is incurred. Advocates for island repair must therefore develop analyses which ensure that repair occurs only when island-insensitivity is observed, namely (18b) as opposed to (18a) (for attempts, see e.g., Fox & Lasnik 2003, Merchant 2008, Griffiths & Liptak 2014).

- (19) ... I don't know who₁ <Abby is happy [_{ISLAND} because *t*₁ won]>.

Island evasion approaches, on the other hand, deny the existence of island repair and instead capture island-insensitivity by appealing to the possibility that ellipsis sites can be anisomorphic to their antecedents (Baker & Brame 1972, Merchant 2001, Abels 2012, Barros et al. 2014). They claim that whenever island-insensitivity is observed, the ellipsis site contains no island. For them, (20) represents the ellipsis site for (18b).

- (20) ... I don't know who₁ <*t*₁ won>.

As foreshadowed in the summary to §2.1, the SQA adopts an island-evasion perspective on island (in)sensitivity under ellipsis. Like other evasion approaches, it predicts that island-sensitivity is observed only when the ellipsis site cannot exhibit an island-evading phrase marker.

Barros (2014b) observes that an ellipsis-independent pragmatic constraint on establishing a discourse relation of Contrast between two utterances can sometimes function to preclude the availability of island-evading, anisomorphic clauses for ellipsis. To see this, consider the simplified *Contrast* rule in (21) and its application in the dialogues in (22) and (23). The utterances in (22) satisfy Contrast because both match in meaning with (24). However, the utterances in (23) do not satisfy Contrast because (23A) matches in meaning with (24), whereas (23B) matches with (25).

(21) *Contrast*

A relation of Contrast is established between two utterances A and B only if both are congruent to (i.e., match in meaning to) the same Q in the QUD.

- (22) A: Abby is happy because BEN left.
 B: No, she is happy because LUCY left.

- (23) A: Abby is happy because BEN left.
B: No, LUCY left.

(24) Q: {Abby is happy because x left : $x \in D_e$ }

(25) Q: { x left : $x \in D_e$ }

In some clausal ellipsis configurations in which the remnant bears contrastive focus, one cannot simultaneously satisfy *Contrast* and evade an island. Because satisfying one constraint entails failing to satisfy the other, such configurations are suboptimal and therefore are judged as degraded or unacceptable. For example, (26) is unacceptable because no viable ellipsis site is available: the short anisomorphic clause evades the island but fails to satisfy *Contrast*, whereas the full isomorphic clause satisfies *Contrast* but crosses an island-boundary.

- (26) * Abby is happy because BEN left, but I don't know which OTHER guest.
a. ... know [which OTHER guest]₁ < t_1 left>.
b. ... know [which OTHER guest]₁ <Abby is happy [_{ISLAND} because t_1 left]>.

Importantly, this dilemma does not arise with contrast sluices and contrast fragments when the short elliptical clause can be interpreted as equivalent in meaning to the antecedent. In such cases, one can simultaneously establish contrast and evade the island, and therefore no unacceptability is engendered. For instance, (27) is acceptable because *she* in the anisomorphic ellipsis site in (28) can function as an E-type pronoun meaning 'the woman that they hired'. Under this interpretation, both the elliptical clause and the antecedent match in meaning with the Q in (29), thus satisfying *Contrast*.

(27) They hired a woman who speaks FRENCH last week, but I don't know which OTHER language.

(28) ... [which OTHER language]₁ <she speaks t_1 >. (she = the woman they hired)

(29) Q: {the woman that they hired speaks x : $x \in D_e$ }

The SQA adopts Barros' (2014b) proposal about how island (in)sensitivity and contrastivity interact with minimal modification (see Griffiths 2019). However, the SQA diverges from the evasion-based approach outlined by Barros and colleagues (Barros 2014b; Barros et al. 2013, 2014) in its predictions regarding the island (in)sensitivity of non-*wh* fragments. Because Barros et al.'s (2014) approach is couched in the MDA, it assumes that all remnants are A'-moved items. Consequently, it predicts that, in any configuration in which the correlate is island-bound and no island-evading anisomorphic clause is available, a non-*wh* fragment is unacceptable, as the remnant has undergone island-crossing *wh*-movement. Conversely, because it maintains that non-*wh* remnants remain in-situ and therefore that no island-crossing A'-movement occurs with them, the SQA predicts that configurations fitting the profile described above are unacceptable only when no viable antecedent is available to license ellipsis, which transpires only when the antecedent is a declarative assertion.⁷ Put differently, both approaches predict that (30B) is unacceptable (which aligns with the judgment reported by Griffiths), but only Barros et al.'s (2014) approach predicts that (31B) is unacceptable. (In both cases, no island-

⁷ Readers who would prefer to avoid reconstructing the logic behind this prediction from the outline of the SQA presented in Section 1 are directed towards Griffiths (2019: §4.2), which presents an explicit walkthrough.

evading, anisomorphic clause is available, as the candidate anisomorphic clause, namely *he is former*, is ungrammatical.)

(30) A: I heard Buckeye Bill is the main source of information in this two-bit town.

B: * **No, former.** He's moved away.

(intended: *he's the former source of information*) (Griffiths 2019:6)

(31) A: Is Buckeye Bill the main source of information in this two-bit town?

B: **No, former.** He's moved away.

2.3 Variations on the *Syntactic Question Approach* to clausal ellipsis

Although §§2.1–2.3 have sufficiently introduced the SQA and how it differs from other silent structure theories, two permutations on Griffiths' (2019) / Griffiths et al.'s (2023) version of the SQA must first be introduced before we can finally proceed from theory to experiments, as these permutations will feature in later sections of this paper.

The first permutation, which we dub the *basic in-situ* approach, agrees with the SQA that non-*wh* remnants of ellipsis remain in-situ but does not adopt the SQA's claim that clausal ellipsis must be licensed by an interrogative utterance. Instead, the basic in-situ approach adopts a simpler licensing condition. The precise content of this condition is irrelevant – what matters is that this condition does not confer onto non-*wh* remnants the hallmarks of A'-movement (unlike the SQA's licensing condition).

The second permutation, which we dub the *cue-retrieval* SQA (SQA_{CUE}), allows for flexibility regarding the status of the licensor of ellipsis. This approach follows the canonical SQA in proposing that clausal ellipsis must be licensed by an explicit or accommodated interrogative utterance but departs from the canonical SQA insofar as it relaxes this constraint under certain conditions. When these 'relaxed' conditions transpire, clausal ellipsis can be licensed merely by the maxQUD, which is a purely semantic object (see §2.1). Let us henceforth refer to these differing licensing scenarios as the *syntactic* and *semantic* strategies, respectively. Which strategy the hearer employs is determined by the formal properties of the remnant of ellipsis. If the remnant displays no morphosyntactic cues for associating it with a particular syntactic position in the ellipsis site, then the more relaxed and less cognitively burdensome semantic strategy is employed. The converse obtains if the remnant displays such morphosyntactic cues. Although what counts as a morphosyntactic cue is a mostly unexplored empirical question (Martin & McElree 2011, Harris 2015), recent research has confirmed that morphological markers of case, gender, and agreement function as such cues (Martin et al. 2012, Nykiel et al. 2022, Cortés Rodríguez 2025).

As mentioned in §1, the current SQA-oriented interpretation of how morphosyntactic cues displayed by the remnant affect the recoverability of ellipsis differs from the more conventional view adopted by Nykiel et al. 2022, who assume that ellipsis recoverability is a uniform process that is simply aided by the presence of cues, which serve to help hearers associate the remnant with its correlate in the antecedent utterance (following Martin & McElree 2008, 2009, 2011, Martin et al., 2012, 2014, Parker 2022). Our interpretation is less conventional, as we are proposing that hearers attempt to resolve morphosyntactic information on a remnant – via comparing the structure of the elliptical clause to the structure of its (accommodated) licensor – only when they must. If no such morphosyntactic information is present, then hearers resolve ellipsis in a manner that can bypass comparing syntactic structures, namely by comparing only meanings (the maxQUD and the meaning of the elliptical clause) instead.

This concludes our presentation of the approaches to clausal ellipsis relevant to the experiments reported in the remainder of the paper. Table 1 provides a summary.

Table 1. A summary of the approaches to clausal ellipsis relevant to Experiments 1–4

must the remnant undergo A'-movement to escape ellipsis?	is island repair permitted?	are anisomorphic ellipsis sites permitted?	does contrastivity effect island sensitivity?	what is the licenser for ellipsis?	approach
yes	yes	no	No	<i>not relevant to Experiments 1–4</i>	traditional island repair (e.g., Lasnik 2001)
	yes	no	yes		variable island repair (e.g., Griffiths & Lipták 2014)
	no	yes	yes		traditional island evasion (Barros et al. 2014)
no	no	yes	yes	an interrogative	the Syntactic Question Approach (Griffiths 2019)
				<i>not relevant</i>	the basic in-situ approach
				either an interrogative or the maxQUD	the Syntax Question Approach plus cue-based retrieval (SQA _{CUE})

2.4 Previous experimental results on island (in)sensitivity under clausal ellipsis and motivation for experiments on adjectival fragments in English and German

So far, we have explicated and motivated the SQA by appealing to acceptability judgment data that were collected informally. Problematically, the reliability of informally collected data on ellipsis phenomena is not guaranteed, primarily because of the small effect sizes involved (for in-depth discussion of this point, see Griffiths 2026). Therefore, one must consider whether the empirical picture obtained via informal data-collection methods is replicated when these data are collected using experimental syntax methods, whose adoption yields more robust results.

In recent years, several experimental studies have examined island sensitivity under clausal ellipsis. While these studies provide many useful insights, critical inspection often reveals conflicting results and systematic methodological oversights. For example, some studies insufficiently control the availability of anisomorphic ellipsis sites, making it impossible to ascertain whether island insensitivity arises via island repair or island evasion. In the remainder of this subsection, we review the relevant experimental findings and argue that the shortcomings in experimental design observed in several studies motivate our experiment series' focus on left-branch extraction, which promises to provide a more constrained testing-ground for island sensitivity under ellipsis.

In a series of 1–7 Likert scale acceptability judgment experiments, Potter (2017) tested island sensitivity under ellipsis in English. He found that fragments whose correlates occur inside definite relative clause (RC) islands such as (32) were judged to be broadly acceptable.⁸

- (32) A: Jordan mocked [_{ISLAND} the salesman who sold a car to an elderly customer].
 B: No, to Ashley. (adapted from Potter 2017: 97)

⁸ For instance, in a representative sub-experiment in which two crossed factors were compared, namely ISLANDHOOD (whether the correlate is island-bound or not) and CONTRAST TYPE (corrective vs. elaborative), Potter found that fragments exemplifying the [+island, +contrast] condition returned an average score of 4.35 out of 7, which is higher than the score returned for their [+island, -contrast] counterparts (4.26). Furthermore, statistical analysis revealed no significant interaction effect (Potter 2017:123).

Similarly, Yoshida et al. (2019) found fragment answers such as (33) to be only minimally – and statistically insignificantly – degraded compared to the baseline condition without an island; see (34).

- (33) A: James met [_{ISLAND} the journalist who got a commissioned piece].
 B: No, a salaried position. (adapted from Yoshida et al. 2019: 1521)

- (34) A: James heard that the journalist got a commissioned piece.
 B: No, a salaried position. (ibid.)

Based on these results, these authors conclude that contrastive ellipsis is island-insensitive and interpret their results as evidence for the existence of island repair under ellipsis. This conclusion is premature, however. According to the island evasion approach outlined in §2.2, there is no expectation of island sensitivity in cases such as (32) and (33), as a short, anisomorphic elliptical clause that obeys the Contrast rule in (21) is available:

- (35) a. (for (32B)): <s/he sold a car> to Ashley. (s/he = the salesman that J mocked)
 b. (for (33B)): <s/he got> a salaried commission. (s/he = the journalist that J met)

Furthermore, neither Potter (2017) nor Yoshida et al. (2019) control for the *utterance-final effect* (Griffiths and Lipták 2014: fn10, Barros et al. 2014, Reeve 2016), which refers to the currently unexplained observation that a fragmentary response will always display an insensitivity to islands if its correlate appears in the linearly final position in the antecedent. Therefore, both the island evasion approach from §2.2 and the island repair approach predicts island insensitivity for Potter’s and Yoshida et al.’s test items, meaning that their experiments on RC-islands are inherently incapable of returning results that support one approach over the other.⁹

Wu (2022) also focuses on configurations in which the correlate is contained in an RC-island. However, unlike Potter and Yoshida et al., she tests cases in which no anisomorphic ‘short source’ is available, due to the fact that employing an E-type pronoun results in semantic incongruity:

- (36) They hired a monolingual who speaks French yesterday, and also German.
 a. ... also <they hired [_{ISLAND} a monolingual who speaks> German]. (full source)
 b. ... also <s/he speaks> German. (short source)
the short source is unavailable, as a monolingual cannot speak both languages

Wu consulted 7 native speakers, all of whom judged (36) as unacceptable, which therefore supports the island evasion over the island repair approach. Although Wu’s consultation was informal and involved a small sample size, we treat Wu’s results as ‘experimental evidence’ here because her data-collection method bears resemblance to Mahowald et al.’s (2016) *SNAP judgment* paradigm, which states that large-scale experimental studies are unnecessary if an informal precursor study with 7 participants returns unanimous results.¹⁰

⁹ Wu (2022) also identifies several methodological concerns in Yoshida et al.’s (2019) study, including issues related to the use of stripping constructions, the manipulation of contrastive focus, and a finality confound in the experimental stimuli.

¹⁰ Note that Wu’s argument is not novel — it originates in Merchant 2001. Merchant employs a non-referential DP to bleed the E-type pronoun reading (ibid.:211):

Palaz et al. (2025) conducted a 1–7 Likert scale acceptability judgment experiment that focused on subject islands in sluicing configurations. They found no significant main effect of ISLAND (*no island* versus *subject island*) and no interaction effect for regular versus contrast sluicing when ISLAND is modulated (see (37) for example test items for each relevant condition).

- (37) a. Megan’s children used to love [the costume of a superhero], but she cannot recall which superhero. (regular sluicing, no island)
 b. [_{ISLAND} The costume of a superhero] used to amaze Megan’s children, but she cannot recall which superhero. (regular sluicing, subject island)
 c. Megan’s children used to love [the costume of Captain America], but she cannot recall which other superhero. (contrast sluicing, no island)
 d. [_{ISLAND} The costume of Captain America] used to amaze Megan’s children, but she cannot recall which other superhero. (contrast sluicing, subject island)

Although Palaz et al. conducted a separate forced-choice experiment whose results show that a copular-clausal anisomorphic clause such as ‘*which it was*’ is unavailable (or strongly dispreferred, at least) for the ellipsis site in contrast sluicing, they neglect to control for the possibility that their participants interpreted the elliptical clauses for the sluices in (37) as involving the non-copular island-evading configurations in (38). If this is true, then the observed (relatively) high mean scores returned for each condition and the absence of relevant statistical effects are expected under the island evasion approach, contrary to Palaz et al.’s conclusions.

- (38) a. ... which (other) superhero <they used to love>
 b. ... which (other) superhero <amazed them>

Less contestable experimental support for the island evasion approach comes from Cortés Rodríguez & Griffiths (2024b), who conducted a 1–7 Likert scale acceptability judgment study on island sensitivity in German and Spanish multiple sluicing (MS). Using German to illustrate their design, they tested configurations such as 0, in which morphological case-marking on the *wh*-words forces either a full or short source interpretation; see (40).

- (39) Greta hat über einen Verkäufer berichtet, [_{ISLAND} der über einen
 Greta has about a.ACC salesman reported who.NOM about a.ACC
 Mitarbeiter gelästert hat], aber ich weiß nicht genau...
 co-worker gossiped has but I know not exactly
 a. ... über welchen Verkäufer über welchen Mitarbeiter.
 about which.ACC salesman about which.ACC co-worker
 b. ... welcher Verkäufer über welchen Mitarbeiter.
 which.NOM salesman about which.ACC co-worker

-
- (i) * They didn’t hire anyone who speaks a Balkan language, but I don’t remember which.
 a. # ... which <s/he speaks>
 b. * ... which <they didn’t hire [_{ISLAND} anyone who speaks]>

Lasnik (2005:263) claims that (i) improves to a “?” judgment if the example is modified to include *certain* (see (ii)). Yoshida and Rottman report that the 10 native speakers that they informally consult agree that (ii) is more acceptable than (i). An island-evasion perspective on this difference would run as follows: adding *certain* increases the specificity of *Balkan language*, which in turns makes the island evading copular-clausal ellipsis site (e.g., ... *which <it was>*) more accessible, which improves acceptability.

- (ii) ? They didn’t hire anyone who speaks a certain Balkan language, but I don’t remember which.

- (40) a. (for (39a)): über welchen Verkäufer <Greta berichtet hat, [_{ISLAND} der> über welche Mitarbeiter <gelästert hat>] (full source)
 b. (for (39b)): welcher Verkäufer über welche Mitarbeiter <gelästert hat> (short source)

They report that, although the average score for both conditions is relatively high (between 4 and 5), the short source consistently returned higher scores, and with the difference reaching statistical significance.

In summary, the empirical picture from the experimental literature is not yet sufficiently sharp. Although a few studies provide reliable results that appear to favour the island evasion approach, others fail to support or undermine any particular approach to island sensitivity under ellipsis, due to the presence of confounds that arise from failing to preclude the presence of an island-evading ellipsis site. Furthermore, the experimental work to date has concentrated on only two types of islands, both of which are clause-sized. A pressing objective for future experimental research is therefore to collect data on a broader range of island configurations, and to ensure that the experiments used to collect this data are free of confounds, particularly relating to structurally ambiguous ellipsis sites.

In an effort to contribute to fulfilling the above-described objective, the members of the project *Cross-Linguistic Experiments on Fragmentary Sentences* (CLEFS) conducted six acceptability judgment experiments on English and German fragments whose correlates are attributive adjectives and are therefore contained in a left-branch island (i.e., a DP). We decided to focus on left-branch extraction (LBE) under clausal ellipsis for two main reasons. The first reason is easily stated: studying LBE offers a straightforward means by which to test the predictions of several competing approaches to clausal ellipsis, including the SQA and its permutations, as will be demonstrated in the following sections. Our second reason concerns the status of the *Left Branch Condition* (LBC, Ross 1967), which appears to be a genuinely syntactic constraint – its source is unlikely to be attributable to processing limitations or pragmatic factors (Culicover et al. 2022), it is subject to crosslinguistic parametric variation (Ross 1967, Abels 2003; Bošković 2005, 2012), and it does not satiate (Lu et al. 2024). Therefore, focusing on LBE under clausal ellipsis allows us to interpret our results in terms of grammatical influences on acceptability as opposed to non-grammatical ones. Put differently, if a particular result could be explained either in grammatical terms (e.g., the ellipsis site evades an island) or non-grammatical terms (e.g., ellipsis mitigates the processing or information-structural burden that comprises the island effect), then the grammatical explanation is favoured, because the LBC describes a grammatical transgression, not a processing problem. Furthermore, if our results demonstrate that the LBC is active under ellipsis, this provides new and independent evidence for the emerging view that the LBC is wholly syntactic in nature.

Two of the experiments on German conducted within this project have already been publicly disseminated; see Griffiths & Schiele 2025 and Schiele 2025, 2026. These experiments tested for signs of LBC-penalties by modulating the morphological marking exhibited by the adjectival fragment: if the adjective is declined, it must originate in an attributive position (and possibly undergo LBE in clausal ellipsis environments), whereas if the adjective is morphologically bare, it must originate as the predicate of a copular clause. These experiments also modulated the remnant type (*wh*-remnant versus non-*wh* remnant) and the type of focus borne by the remnant (corrective versus presentational). The results returned for these experiments strongly support an in-situ approach to ellipsis. However, these experiments were not designed to adjudicate between different versions of the in-situ approach or to provide direct evidence that island-sensitivity obtains under ellipsis. For this and other reasons, we conducted partial replication studies that were designed to overcome these shortcomings. It is the partial replication studies that are reported in §§6–7. A detailed comparison of the experiments reported

in §§6–7 and those reported in Griffiths & Schiele 2025 and Schiele 2025, 2026 is presented in §8.

3. Background on experiments on adjectival fragments in English and German

This section outlines the methods and practicalities common to all of the experiments comprising our series.

3.1 Methods and practicalities common to all experiments

The series consists of three within-subjects experiments in which participants rated the naturalness of stimuli on a 1–7 Likert scale (1 = fully unnatural, 7 = fully natural), and one within-subject experiment in which participants chose which member from a pair of minimally different stimuli seems most natural.

All experiments were designed using *PsychoPy* (Peirce et al. 2019) and hosted online by *Pavlovia*. Each experiment comprised a consent screen, demographic screens (age, gender, and other language (if any)), instruction screens, a practice round, and a trial round. In the Likert scale experiments, participants were instructed to rate the naturalness of the second utterance in a two-utterance dialogue between speaker A and speaker B, and to take the context provided by speaker A’s utterance into account when rating. In the forced-choice experiment, participants were instructed to choose the dialogue in which speaker B’s utterance seems most natural, relative to speaker A’s utterance from each dialogue. In the Likert scale experiments, the practice round comprised 5 to 7 dialogues (based on stimuli from Sprouse et al. 2013, for the English experiments) that attempted to elicit responses at every point on the 1–7 Likert scale. In the forced-choice experiment, the practice round comprised 5 dialogue-pairs for which the difference in naturalness between the pairs’ members clearly varied. The trial round comprised a pseudorandomized mix of test items, (standardized) filler items, and attention checks.

For each experiment, 12 lexical sets of test items were developed. The items from these sets were then distributed over 4 lists in a Latin square pattern, resulting in 3 repetitions per condition per participant. For the 2×2 experiments (Experiments 2 and 3), a member of a lexical set appeared only once per list. For the $2 \times 2 \times 2$ experiments (Experiments 1 and 4), two members of a lexical set appeared per list. The ratio of test items to fillers ranged from 6:7 (Experiment 1) to 6:5 (Experiment 4). The standardized fillers used in our English experiments were adapted from those developed by Gerbrich et al. 2019 (for English).

3.2 Participants

Participants were recruited using *Prolific*. Participants were screened for being over 18 years old, speaking British English / German as their native and primary language, spending the first 18 years of their life in the British Isles / Germany, and having a 95%+ approval rate on *Prolific*. Participants were automatically ejected and received no payment if, during the “demographic” part of an experiment, they did not consent to participating or if they self-reported as a non-native speaker or as someone who did not grow up in the British Isles / Germany. Participants were manually rejected, which entails receiving no payment, if they failed attention checks interspersed between each experiment’s test items and fillers. Furthermore, a participant was identified as an outlier if either (i) the difference between their rating for a particular standardized filler and its expected score (when averaged over these fillers) departed from grand mean difference by 2 or more standard deviations, or (ii) their mean rating for a clearly (un)acceptable filler item departed from the grand mean difference by two or more standard deviations. Data collected from automatically ejected, manually rejected, or outlier participants were excluded

from statistical analyses. Table 2 presents the figures related to participant recruitment, payment, and exclusion.

Table 2. Participant recruitment and exclusion for Experiments 1–4

experiment	when conducted	payment (£ / hr)	participants recruited	participants excluded		participants in analysis	obs. per condition
				<i>att. check</i>	<i>outlier</i>		
1: English	Oct 2024	9	60	1	0	59	177
2: English	May 2026	18	44	0	2	42	126
3: German	May 2026	18.80	34	2	4	28	84
4: German	May 2026	18.85	40	1	4	35	105

Recent experimental syntax research on syntactic locality effects under ellipsis has shown that ~100 observations per condition appears to be sufficient to avoid type II errors (Cortés Rodríguez 2025, Griffiths 2026, Schiele in press). Fortunately, Experiment 3 returned statistically significant non-null results despite its comparatively small sample size, as will be demonstrated in §6.

3.3 Analyses

Cumulative link mixed-effect models (CLMMs) were fit to the 1–7 Likert scale data, using the *ordinal* package (Christensen 2019) in *R* (R Core Team 2026). Logistic mixed-effect regression models were fit to the forced-choice data, using the *lme4* package (Bates et al. 2015) in *R*. The model estimates and inferential contrasts reported in §§4–7 were taken from models that include all designated independent variables as fixed effects and which display the best-fitting random effects structure, as determined by manual backwards model comparison, using maximum likelihood testing, via *R*’s *anova()* function. The planned and post-hoc pairwise comparisons of model estimates reported in §4 and §5 were conducted using the *emmeans* package (Lenth et al. 2026) in *R*.

4. Experiment 1 (English)

In this section, we present the first experiment from our series. Experiment 1 was a 1–7 Likert scale acceptability judgment task that examined the effect of LBE under clausal ellipsis in English, focusing on non-*wh* adjectival fragments.

4.1 Experiment 1: Background and motivation

Recall from §0 that Barros et al.’s (2014) approach to island evasion predicts that non-*wh* fragments for which no anisomorphic clause is available and whose antecedent is an interrogative should be unacceptable, whereas the SQA predicts that such fragments should be acceptable. Our first experiment tested fragments that fit this profile to determine which island evasion approach’s prediction is borne out.

The experiment employed two methods for blocking island-evading anisomorphic clauses. The first, which comes from Barros et al. (2014) and is an undisputable blocker of anisomorphic clauses, was to employ attributive-only adjectives such as *former*, *debut*, *honourary*, *principal*, *avid*, *leading*, and *occasional* as ellipsis remnants (41). A copular clausal, anisomorphic ellipsis site is blocked in this case because the adjective cannot function as a predicate (i.e., *she is debut* is ungrammatical). The second method was to employ adjectival remnants that can function both attributively and predictively (henceforth referred to as *ambiguous* adjectives) but modulate the type of focus that they bear – either presentational or contrastive (compare (42)

and (43)). A copular clausal, anisomorphic ellipsis is allegedly blocked when the fragment bears contrastive focus because a relation of contrast can only be established between two utterances – in this case, the elliptical utterance and its antecedent – when both answer the same Q in the QUD (recall the Contrast rule in (21) from §2.2), which does not occur in the LBE scenarios being tested when an anisomorphic ellipsis site is employed (for instance, *she is now a successful novelist* and the copula clause *she is unsuccessful* do not answer the same Q). Because this second method presumes that Barros (2014b) is correct in that contrast bleeds an anisomorphic ellipsis site when the Contrast rule is unmet, which is a disputable claim (one that Palaz et al. 2025 have already attempted to test for subject islands; see §2.4), the experiment also functions to test this claim.

(41) A: Is she a high-profile novelist?

B: No, debut.

(42) A: Is she now a novelist?

B: Yes, very successful.

(43) A: Is she now a high-profile novelist?

B: No, unsuccessful.

Coincidentally, the experiment also tests the predictions of the island-repair approaches to island (in)sensitivity developed by Fox & Lasnik (2003) and Griffiths & Lipták (2014), which both predict that all contrast sluices and contrast fragments are island-sensitive, as the contrastive remnant is assumed to undergo island-crossing LF-movement, which is not repaired by ellipsis (see *ibid.* for the technical details).

We also included non-elliptical counterparts to each elliptical test condition in the experimental design. Doing this not only provided baselines but also permitted us to examine whether the presence of contrastive focus incurs a general acceptability penalty (caused by the additional pragmatic burden of determining if a contrast relation holds between two clauses), or if this penalty is more acute for elliptical utterances. If we find that contrast negatively effects judgments for all and only our elliptical test items, then this will partially replicate the experimental result obtained for sluicing by Palaz et al. (2025).

4.2 Experiment 1: Materials and Possible Outcomes

Experiment 1 exhibited a $2 \times 2 \times 2$ design, testing the factors ELLIPSIS (*no-ellipsis* vs *ellipsis*), ADJECTIVE (*attributive-only* vs *ambiguous*), and FOCUS (*contrastive* vs *presentational*). A lexical set exemplifying each condition is presented in (44)–(47).

(44) A: Is she now a novelist?

a. B: Yes, she's a debut novelist.

[no-ellipsis, attributive-only, presentational]

b. B: Yes, she's very successful.

[no-ellipsis, ambiguous, presentational]

(45) A: Is she now a novelist?

a. B: Yes, debut.

[ellipsis, attributive-only, presentational]

b. B: Yes, very successful.

[ellipsis, ambiguous, presentational]

(46) A: Is she a high-profile novelist?

a. B: No, she's a debut novelist.

[no-ellipsis, attributive-only, contrastive]

b. B: No, she's unsuccessful.

[no-ellipsis, ambiguous, contrastive]

- (47) A: Is she a high-profile novelist?
 a. B: No, debut. [ellipsis, attributive-only, contrastive]
 b. B: No, unsuccessful. [ellipsis, ambiguous, contrastive]

The relevant possible outcomes (POs) of Experiment 1 are presented in Table 3.

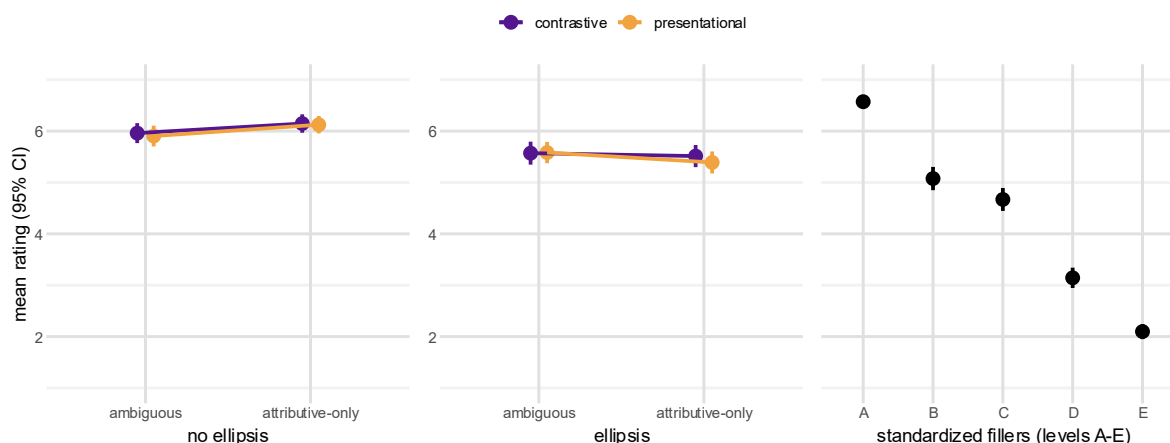
Table 3. The relevant possible outcomes (POs) of Experiment 1.

Scenario 1. No significant difference obtains between any of the high-scoring <i>no-ellipsis</i> conditions. In the <i>ellipsis</i> condition:		
	<i>Statistically significant results</i>	<i>suggest that</i>
PO1	a main effect of ADJECTIVE	- non-<i>wh</i> remnants undergo A'-movement - island evasion exists - contrast does not block an anisomorphic source
PO2	- a main effect of ADJECTIVE - an interaction effect between ADJECTIVE and FOCUS	- non-<i>wh</i> remnants undergo A'-movement - island evasion exists - contrast blocks an anisomorphic source
PO3	a main effect of FOCUS	- non-<i>wh</i> remnants undergo A'-movement - island repair exists, but is unavailable in contrast sluices and contrast fragments
PO4	none	- non-<i>wh</i> remnants remain in-situ, or - non-<i>wh</i> remnants undergo A'-movement - island repair exists and is available for all sluices and fragments
Scenario 2. A main significant effect of FOCUS obtains in the <i>no-ellipsis</i> condition:		
	<i>Result</i>	<i>suggests that</i>
PO5	none	the presence of contrast yields an acceptability penalty that is independent of ellipsis

4.3 Experiment 1: Results

The mean ratings across conditions for test items, and the mean ratings for each A to E level for the standardized filler items, are presented in Figure 1.

Figure 1. Mean ratings for test items (left and centre) and standardized fillers (right) from Experiment 1.



One observes that the non-elliptical conditions all score highly (within the standardized filler levels A and B). Furthermore, the best-fitting CLMM for the *no-ellipsis* data-subset returned no significant main effects or interaction effect between any condition. Therefore, Scenario 1 from Table 1 obtained.

Based on this, the analysis then focused solely on the *ellipsis* items. The best-fitting interaction model for this subset of Experiment 1's results, which fit random intercepts for subjects and items, returned no main significant mean effect for ADJECTIVE ($\beta = -0.13$, $z = -0.92$, $p = 0.35$), FOCUS ($\beta = -0.08$, $z = -0.52$, $p = 0.60$), or their interaction ($\beta = -0.04$, $SD = z = 0.30$, $p = 0.77$), meaning that PO4 from Table 1 transpired.¹¹

4.4 Experiment 1: Discussion

The results for Experiment 1 are informative insofar as they are incompatible with and therefore undermine several analyses of clausal ellipsis that presuppose that remnants undergo A'-movement. For instance, the results are incompatible with Fox & Lasnik's (2003) and Griffiths & Lipták's (2014) analyses, which each state that remnants A'-move, that island repair exists, and that island violations cannot be repaired for contrast sluices and contrast fragments. Similarly, the results are incompatible with analyses couched in the MDA that permit island-evading sources, regardless of whether such analyses stipulate a blanket ban on island-evading sources when the remnant bears contrastive focus, or whether they stipulate no such ban (Barros et al. 2014). Because the experiment's results are incompatible with Barros et al.'s island evasion approach, they indirectly support the SQA, and therefore the experiment has fulfilled its goals (which were stated in §4.1.)

However, it is important to stress that Experiment 1's support for the SQA is only indirect. This is because the results for Experiment 1 are also underinformative, insofar as they are compatible with four competing analyses, namely the SQA, the traditional island repair analysis (i.e., all remnants A'-move and islands are always repaired; Lasnik 2001, 2005), the 'basic' in-situ analysis (i.e., an analysis that adopts all of the same assumptions as the SQA aside from its stipulation that clausal ellipsis must be licensed by an interrogative), and a version of the SQA that adopts a cue-based retrieval view of ellipsis recoverability (recall §2.3, in particular Table 1). The cue-based retrieval version of the SQA – namely, SQA_{CUE} – is a viable analysis on this occasion because English adjectives exhibit no morphosyntactic cue betraying the syntactic position with which they are associated. In other words, from a purely morpho-syntactic perspective, English adjectival fragments are always ambiguous between occupying an attributive or a predicative position within the elliptical clause. The absence of a morpho-syntactic cue permits the hearer to adopt the semantic strategy for ellipsis licensing, which requires only that the meaning of the elliptical clause is a congruent answer to the maxQUD. Because this scenario involves no A'-movement in either the elliptical clause or the antecedent, complete island-insensitivity is predicted.

Note that Experiment 1's underinformativity is a byproduct of its design: Experiment 1 is inherently incapable of returning results that can distinguish between the four above-described analyses.

Finally, Experiment 1 was designed such that indirect support for the SQA would arise only in the event of a null result. However, this design choice is conceptually problematic, as it

¹¹ The statistical analysis of Experiment 1's results was originally conducted by Miriam Schiele. The statistical results presented in the main text come from re-analysis of the experiment's results, which was conducted by this paper's first author. In addition, Miriam Schiele was involved in the conception of the experiment, the development of the stimuli, and its preregistration. Miriam Schiele also contributed to writing a first draft of this paper. The paper has since been entirely re-written.

raises concerns that, even though it involved 177 observations per condition, the experiment was nonetheless underpowered or insufficiently sensitive to detect existing contrasts.

In order to more directly test the SQA and allay concerns about experimental sensitivity, we conducted an additional experiment on English adjectival fragments, which employed a forced-choice task, which is statistically more sensitive than a 1–7 Likert scale task (Sprouse & Almeida 2017). This experiment is reported in the following section.

5. Experiment 2 (English)

5.1 Experiment 2: Background and motivation

Recall from §2.2 that the SQA makes a prediction that no other analysis makes, namely that the clause-type of the antecedent can influence island sensitivity. Specifically, the SQA predicts that, when an island-evading ellipsis site is unavailable, island sensitivity is observed when the antecedent is a declarative assertion, whereas island insensitivity is observed if the antecedent is a polar or alternative question (the reasoning behind this prediction was already outlined in §§2.1–2.2). Applied to LBE scenarios, the SQA predicts that an attributive-only adjectival fragment such as (48B) is unacceptable or degraded relative to its counterpart in (49B) (these examples are repeated from §2.2).

- (48) A: I heard Buckeye Bill is the main source of information in this two-bit town.
B: * **No, former.** He's moved away.
(intended: *he's the former source of information*) (judgment from Griffiths 2019:6)

- (49) A: Is Buckeye Bill the main source of information in this two-bit town?
B: **No, former.** He's moved away.

Experiment 2 tests this prediction. Rather than using a 1–7 Likert scale task, a forced-choice task is employed in order to pre-emptively address concerns about experimental sensitivity. Experiment 2 also retests for the influence of FOCUS, with the aim of replicating the null result returned in Experiment 1.

5.2 Experiment 2: Materials and Possible Outcomes

Experiment 2 tested two factors, ANTECEDENT (*declarative* versus *polar question*) and FOCUS (*contrastive* versus *presentational*), with the percentage choice between ADJECTIVE (*attributive-only* versus *ambiguous*) serving as the dependent variable. A lexical set exemplifying each condition-pair is presented in (50) to (53).

- (50) **Pair 1:** [*declarative, attributive-only*] vs. [*declarative, ambiguous*] in *presentational*

- a. A: Apparently, she's a novelist.
B: Yes, debut.
- b. A: Apparently, she's a novelist.
B: Yes, high-profile.

- (51) **Pair 2:** [*declarative, attributive-only*] vs. [*declarative, ambiguous*] in *contrastive*

- a. A: Apparently, she's a veteran novelist.
B: No, debut.
- b. B: Apparently, she's a veteran novelist.
B: No, inexperienced.

(52) **Pair 3:** [*polar Q, attributive-only*] vs. [*polar Q, ambiguous*] in *presentational*

- a. A: Is she a novelist?
B: Yes, debut.
- b. A: Is she a novelist?
B: Yes, high-profile.

(53) **Pair 4:** [*polar Q, attributive-only*] vs. [*polar Q, ambiguous*] in *contrastive*

- a. A: Is she a veteran novelist?
B: No, debut.
- b. A: Is she a veteran novelist?
B: No, inexperienced.

Participants were instructed to compare the two dialogues that comprise each pair and select the dialogue that seems most natural. To ensure that this judgment is not influenced by the word choice, length, and/or syntactic complexity of the antecedent, speaker A's utterance must be kept constant within a single pair. Because adopting a full factorial design in which ANTECEDENT and FOCUS are directly compared would involve comparing dialogues in which the antecedent differs, Experiment 2 only directly compared the levels of FOCUS, with the influence of modulating ANTECEDENT tested indirectly via difference-in-differences (DiD) statistical comparisons (i.e., through calculating interaction effects).

The relevant possible outcomes (POs) of Experiment 2 are presented in Table 4.

Table 4. The relevant possible outcomes (POs) of Experiment 2.

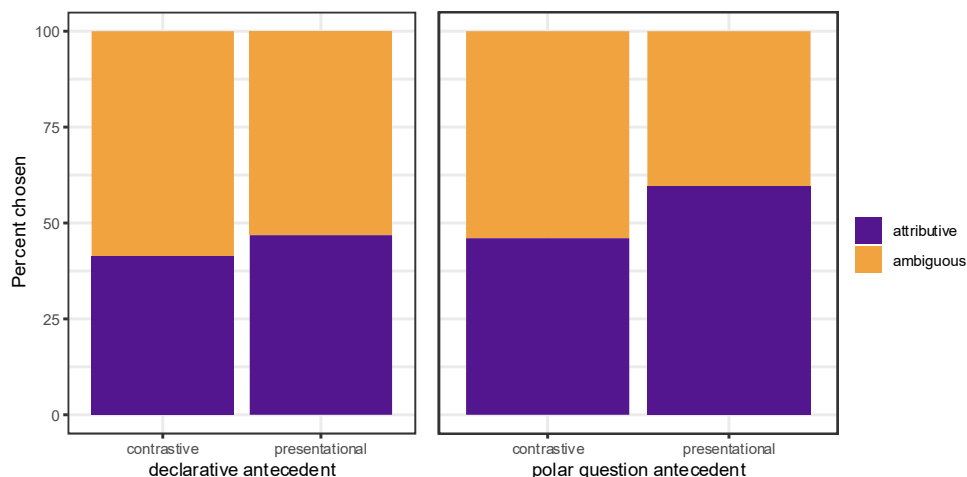
	<i>Statistically significant results</i>	<i>suggest that</i>
PO1	a main effect of FOCUS	- non-<i>wh</i> remnants undergo A'-movement - island repair exists, but is unavailable in contrast sluices and contrast fragments
PO2	a main effect of ANTECEDENT	- island evasion exists - non-<i>wh</i> remnants remain in-situ, but no implicit antecedent can be accommodated when the antecedent is declarative (following the SQA) - contrast does not block an anisomorphic source
PO3	an interaction effect between ANTECEDENT and FOCUS	- island evasion exists - non-<i>wh</i> remnants remain in-situ, but no implicit antecedent can be accommodated when the antecedent is declarative (following the SQA) - contrast blocks an anisomorphic source
PO4	none	- non-<i>wh</i> remnants remain in-situ - the clause type of the antecedent does not affect ellipsis licensing in general (<i>contra</i> the SQA), or
		- non-<i>wh</i> remnants remain in-situ - the clause type of the antecedent does not affect ellipsis licensing in this specific scenario, as the semantic strategy for ellipsis licensing is employed (following the SQA_{CUE}), or

		• non-<i>wh</i> remnants undergo A'-movement • island repair exists and is available for all sluices and fragments
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5.3 Experiment 2: Results

The proportion of choices (given as a percentage) of *attributive-only* and *ambiguous* across the experimental conditions are presented in Figure 2.

Figure 2. Percent chosen between the levels of ADJECTIVE across conditions in Experiment 2.



As Figure 2 shows, the probability that a participant will choose an *attributive-only* or *ambiguous* test item tends towards 50% in all conditions. The best-fitting logistic mixed-effect regression model including both factors as fixed effects, which included random intercepts only for items, returned no significant main effect for either ANTECEDENT ($\beta = 0.21$, $z = 1.29$, $p = 0.20$) or FOCUS ($\beta = 0.22$, $z = 1.36$, $p = 0.18$). No significant interaction effect was observed, either ($\beta = 0.09$, $z = 0.54$, $p = 0.59$). Furthermore, planned pairwise comparisons revealed no significant contrasts between individual conditions. Therefore, PO4 from Table 4 obtains.

5.4 Experiment 2: Discussion

Despite employing a more statistically powerful and more sensitive task than Experiment 1, Experiment 2 nonetheless returned null results. Because it predicts an effect of modulating the clause-type of the antecedent, the canonical version of the SQA is undermined by experiment 2's results.

Taken together, the results from our experiments on English are compatible with three theories of clausal ellipsis with adjectival remnants, namely the traditional island-repair analysis, the basic in-situ approach, and the SQA_{CUE} .

Because both of the English experiments returned null results, the concern remains that both of these experiments were insufficiently sensitive to reveal contrasts that, at least according to impressionistic judgments presented in the literature, actually exist. To address concerns about experimental sensitivity and to better adjudicate between the three remaining competing analyses, we conducted further experiments on German. German declines its attributive adjectives and therefore provides the hearer with a morphosyntactic cue for discerning with which position in the elliptical clause an adjectival fragment is associated. If our experiments on English were insufficiently powered, then our German experiments, which employ similar sample

sizes to the English ones, should also return null results. However, if the German experiments return non-null results, then the SQA_{CUE} is favoured.

6. Experiment 3 (German)

6.1 Experiment 3: Background

In German, an attributive adjective is inflected for agreement with its noun, whereas predicate adjectives are morphologically bare:

(54) Der Mann ist groß(*-en).
The man is tall(*-MASC.ACC)
'The man is tall.'

(55) Lena hat ein-en groß*(-en) Mann geheiratet.
Lena has a-ACC tall*-MASC.ACC man married
'Lena married a tall man.'

If one assumes that the presence of contextual morphology on a remnant of ellipsis indicates that the remnant has entered into standard agreement dependency with a head inside the ellipsis site (this has been the consensus position since Ross 1969), then, in the case of German adjectival fragments, the structure of the ellipsis site can be identified from the morphological form of the remnant. For instance, the accusatively case-marked adjectival fragment in (56a) must occupy / originate within a direct object, meaning that the ellipsis site must be structurally isomorphic to the antecedent, as in (57a). Conversely, the morphologically bare adjective in (56b) must be the predicate of a copular clause, meaning that the ellipsis site must be anisomorphic, as in (57b). This method for controlling the structural form of the ellipsis site can therefore be exploited as an additional method for testing competing claims about island sensitivity under ellipsis.

(56) A: Lena hat ein-en groß-en Mann geheiratet.
Lena has a-MASC.ACC tall-MASC.ACC man married
'Lena married a tall man.'

a. B: Ja, sehr groß-en.
Yes, very tall-ACC

b. B: Ja, sehr groß.
Yes, very tall

(57) a. For (56a): <Lena hat einen> sehr groß-**en** <Mann geheiratet>.
b. For (56b): <er ist> sehr groß. *'he is very tall'*

Recall from §Formal licensing, ellipsis identity, and accommodated antecedents2.1 and §5 that, according to the SQA, the clause-type of the antecedent determines whether a fragment with an island-bound correlate displays island sensitivity or not. If the antecedent is a declarative assertion, and if no island evading source is available, then island sensitivity is expected. Conversely, if the antecedent is a polar or alternative question, then island insensitivity is expected, even if no island evading source is available.

Additionally, recall from §2.2 that the SQA adopts Barros' (2014b) and Griffiths' (2019) proposal that, in certain situations (adjectival fragment configurations being one such situation), the ellipsis site must be interpreted as syntactically isomorphic to the antecedent clause when the remnant of ellipsis bears contrastive focus.

6.2 Experiment 3: Materials and possible outcomes

Experiment 3 focused on *wh*-fragments (sluicing). Because the in-situ approaches being considered in this paper assume that *wh*-movement will take place in an elliptical clause C if it takes place in the non-elliptical counterpart to C (*contra* Abe 2015, 2016), Experiment 3 serves to first establish whether LBE is island-sensitive under clausal ellipsis. It exhibited a 2 × 2 design, testing the factor ADJECTIVE (*marked* versus *bare*) and the factor ELLIPSIS (*ellipsis* versus *no ellipsis*). The latter factor was included to determine whether the negative effect on acceptability of using a declined adjectival fragment is as large as the negative effect of LBE in a non-elliptical *wh*-clause. If so, then this provides strong evidence that the declined adjective is judged as degraded because its creation involves island-violating movement within an elliptical clause. An exemplar lexical set from Experiment 3 is presented in (58). All test items employed presentational focus on the fragment.¹²

- (58) A: Sie ist ein-e reich-e Frau.
 She is a-FEM rich-FEM woman.
 'She is a rich woman.'
- a. B: Oh? Wie reich? [ellipsis, bare]
 oh how rich
 'Oh? How rich?'
- b. B: Oh? Wie reich-e? [ellipsis, marked]
 oh how rich-FEM
 'Oh? How rich?'
- c. B: Oh? Wie reich ist sie? [no-ellipsis, bare]
 oh how rich is she
 'Oh? How rich is she?'
- d. B: Oh? Wie reiche ist sie eine Frau? [no-ellipsis, marked]
 oh how rich-FEM is she a woman
 * 'Oh? How rich is she a woman?'

The relevant possible outcomes of Experiment 3 are presented in Table 5.

¹² The experimental items employed in the German experiments reported in §7.2 and §7.2 differed from those used in the experiments reported in Griffiths & Schiele 2025 and Schiele 2025, 2026 in two relevant ways: (i) the antecedent clauses of our test items were always copular-clausal, whereas antecedents in the previous experiments involved full, lexical verbs, and (ii) the previous experiments used a set of standardized filler items (designed by Miriam Schiele), whereas we used a bespoke, non-standardized set of fillers.

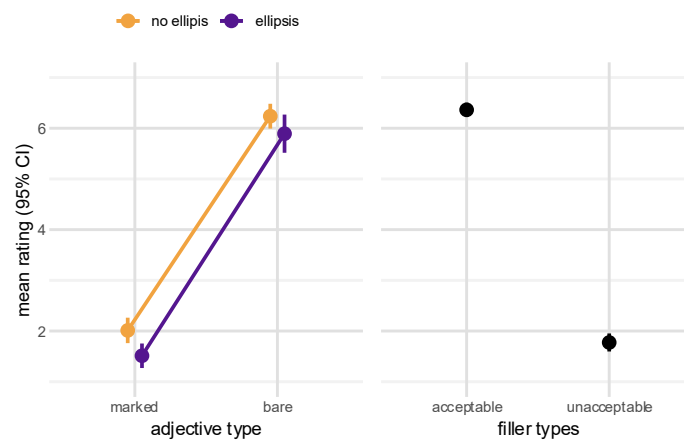
Table 5. The relevant possible outcomes (POs) of Experiment 3.

	<i>Result</i>	<i>suggests that</i>
PO1	• A significant main effect of ADJECTIVE • No significant interaction effect	• island evasion exists
PO2	• Both <i>ellipsis</i> conditions receive a high mean rating • A significant interaction effect	• island repair exists
PO3	• Both <i>ellipsis</i> conditions receive a low mean rating • No significant interaction effect	• island repair does not exist • island evasion does not exist

6.3 Experiment 3: Results

The mean ratings across test conditions for Experiment 3, and the mean ratings for the uncontroversially (un)acceptable filler items included in the experiment, are plotted in Figure 3.

Figure 3. Mean ratings for test items (left) and filler items (right) from Experiment 3.



The best-fitting model that included both factors as fixed effects fit random intercepts for both subjects and items. Running contrasts over this model revealed a highly significant main effect of both ADJECTIVE ($\beta = 3.65$, $z = 10.91$, $p < 0.01$) and ELLIPSIS ($\beta = 0.65$, $z = 2.22$, $p = 0.03$), but no significant interaction effect ($\beta = 0.32$, $z = 1.45$, $p = 0.14$).

Regarding the significant main effect of ELLIPSIS, post-hoc pairwise comparisons of the model's estimated marginal means revealed that modulating ellipsis has a marginally significant effect when the adjective is declined ($\Delta = 1.62$, $z = 2.58$, $p = 0.05$), but not when it is bare ($\Delta = 0.34$, $z = 0.55$, $p = 0.94$).

6.4 Experiment 3: Discussion

Because modulating between the *bare* and *marked* levels of ADJECTIVE yields a highly negative effect on acceptability to the same extent in both sluices and their non-elliptical counterparts, PO1 from Table 5 transpires. In other words, Experiment 3's results represent this paper's first piece of decisive, positive evidence for the island evasion approach to variable island-sensitivity under clausal ellipsis. Furthermore, these results provide strong evidence against adopting a traditional island-repair approach to LBE under clausal ellipsis.

We refrain from interpreting the significant difference between the elliptical and non-elliptical *marked* conditions in Experiment 3 as linguistically meaningful. Instead, we conclude that both *marked* conditions are equally unacceptable but, because their rating-variance is low (i.e.,

Note that Experiment 3's results severely misalign with the only informal judgments provided in the literature, which come from Merchant (2001:173), who reports that adjectival sluicing in German is judged as “??” regardless of whether the adjective is marked or bare.¹³

7.1 Experiment 4: Background

7.2 Experiment 4: Materials and possible outcomes

(59) A: Das ist eine groß-e Höhle.
That is a-FEM big-FEM cave
'That's a big cave.'

a. B: Nein, klein. [declarative, bare, contrastive]
no small
'No, small.'

b. B: Nein, klein-e. [declarative, marked, contrastive]
no small-FEM
'No, small.'

c. B: Ja, sehr groß. [declarative, bare, presentational]
yes very big
'Yes, very big.'

(i) Zij hebben een lange man aangesteld, maar ik weet niet hoe lang(*e)
they have a tall-AGR man hired but I know not how tall(-AGR)

(ii) * Every businessman wants an expensive watch, but I don't know which businessman how expensive.
(Cortés Rodríguez 2022:428)

- d. B: Ja, sehr groß-e. [declarative, marked, presentational]
 yes very big-FEM
 'Yes, very big.'
- (60) A: Ist das eine groß-e Höhle?
 is that a-FEM big-FEM cave
 'Is that a big cave?'
- a. B: Nein, klein. [polar question, bare, contrastive]
 no small
 'No, small.'
- b. B: Nein, klein-e. [polar question, marked, contrastive]
 no small-FEM
 'No, small.'
- c. B: Ja, sehr groß. [polar question, bare, presentational]
 yes very big
 'Yes, very big.'
- d. B: Ja, sehr groß-e. [polar question, marked, presentational]
 yes very big-FEM
 'Yes, very big.'

Because the results of Experiment 3 provide strong evidence for an island evasion approach, and because the possible outcomes that can distinguish between various island evasions are rather complicated for Experiment 4, we refrain from presenting these outcomes in table-format, as done for Experiments 1–3. Instead, we describe them below in prose.

If Barros et al.'s move-and-delete island-evasion approach is correct, then one expects that modulating the clause-type of the antecedent has no effect on acceptability. Instead, all *marked* adjectival fragments should be judged as unacceptable. Furthermore, if Barros is correct that the Contrast rule from §2.2 affects the licensing of clausal ellipsis, then one expects that the fragments in the [*bare, contrast*] condition are also unacceptable, as Contrast forces the ellipsis site for such fragments to be syntactically isomorphic to the antecedent clause, yet these fragments do not display the morphological marking that they should if the ellipsis site is syntactically parallel to its antecedent. Crucially, Barros et al.'s island evasion approach predicts that the marked non-*wh* adjectival fragments return the same floor-level ratings as the marked *wh*-adjectival fragments tested in Experiment 3, as, according to this approach, both *wh*- and non-*wh* adjectival fragments undergo island-violating A'-movement.

The basic in-situ approach predicts radically different results to Barros et al.'s. According to this analysis, which assumes that non-*wh* fragments do not undergo A'-movement and that no A'-movement occurs in the licenser of ellipsis, one expects that both the *marked* and *bare* fragments return high ratings, as no island-violations occur in any condition. The only exception is the [*bare, contrast*] condition, in which an isomorphic ellipsis site is forced and yet the remnant displays the wrong morphological marking for an adjective that must occupy an attributive position (assuming that the Contrast rule indeed applies, of course).

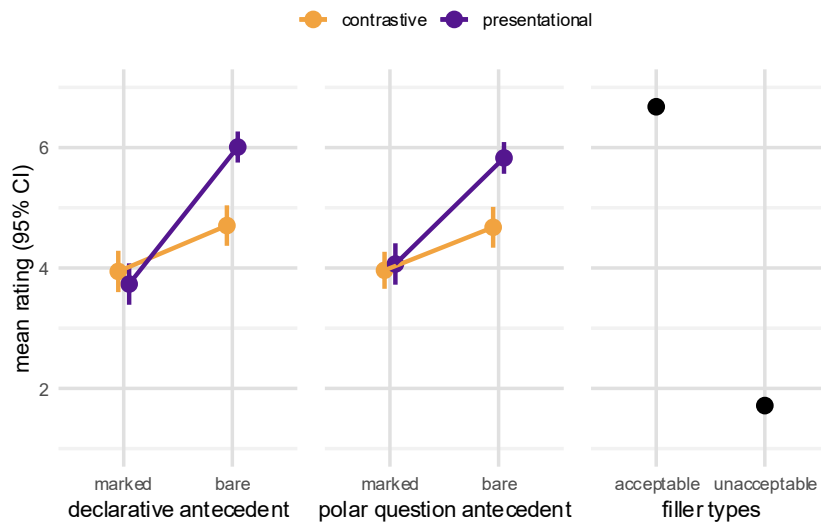
As discussed already in §6, a comparison of the results from the English experiments and the results from the German experiment in §6 show that the canonical SQA as outlined in Griffiths (2019) must be supplemented with a *cue-based retrieval* mechanism, which states that using the syntactic strategy for ellipsis licensing is required only when remnant displays a morphosyntactic cue to its syntactic origins (otherwise, the simpler semantic strategy is employed). This supplement is required to account for the fact that the English experiments returned null results, whereas the German experiment in §6 returned non-null results. Therefore,

we need only consider the predictions of the supplemented version of the SQA (SQA_{CUE}) here. SQA_{CUE} makes two predictions that the other island evasion approaches do not. First, it predicts that the clause-type of the antecedent will affect ratings: *marked* adjectival fragments should be degraded when the antecedent clause is declarative but not when the antecedent is clause is a polar question. This is because, in the ‘declarative’ case, a *wh*-interrogative antecedent must be accommodated, which is impossible in this instance because deriving the accommodated antecedent requires island-violating *wh*-movement, whereas, in the ‘polar question’ case, the antecedent is already a suitable licenser. Second, it predicts that the acceptability penalty incurred for *marked* fragments is not as acute as in Experiment 3. This is because the *marked* fragments in Experiment 3 have undergone island-violating A'-movement, which, as a grammatical transgression, yields a large negative effect on acceptability, whereas the *marked* fragments in the current experiment do not undergo A'-movement but simply cannot be correctly licensed, which is merely a pragmatic transgression (Griffiths 2019). Regarding the Contrast rule, SQA_{CUE} makes the same prediction about [*bare, contrast*]-fragments as the other island evasion accounts, for the same reason.

7.3 Experiment 4: Results

The mean ratings across test conditions for Experiment 4, and the mean ratings for the uncontroversially (un)acceptable filler items included in the experiment, are plotted in Figure 4.

Figure 4. Mean ratings for test items (left and centre) and filler items (right) from Experiment 4.



The best-fitting model for Experiment 4’s results that included all three independent variables as fixed effects exhibited random intercepts for subjects and items. Contrasts run over this model revealed an insignificant main effect of ANTECEDENT ($\beta = 0.01$, $z = 0.160$, $p = 0.873$), a highly significant main effect of ADJECTIVE ($\beta = 1.07$, $z = 10.91$, $p < 0.01$), and a significant main effect of FOCUS ($\beta = 0.52$, $z = 5.54$, $p < 0.01$). Regarding interaction effects, the interaction between ADJECTIVE and FOCUS was significant ($\beta = 0.55$, $z = 5.85$, $p < 0.01$), but all other two- and three-way interactions were not.

Post-hoc pairwise comparisons revealed that no significant difference obtains between the mean ratings for declined adjectival fragments, regardless of whether such fragments are contrastively or presentationally focused or whether their antecedents are a declarative assertion or a polar question. Furthermore, the difference in mean ratings that obtains between the two *contrastive* conditions (i.e., the yellow slopes in Figure 4) is only marginally significant

when the antecedent is a declarative assertion ($\Delta = 1.11$, $z = 3.05$, $p = 0.05$) and insignificant when the antecedent is a polar question ($\Delta = 1.02$, $z = 2.82$, $p = 0.09$).

7.4 Experiments 4: Discussion

Although the results of Experiment 4 are not straightforwardly compatible with any of the island evasion analyses discussed in the previous subsection, they seem most compatible with the SQA_{CUE}. This is because the *marked* fragments are indeed degraded relative to the baseline [*bare*, *presentational*] condition, yet the size of this negative effect is much smaller than the negative effect observed for *marked* fragments in Experiment 3.¹⁴ Note that Experiment 4's results also provide evidence for Barros' proposal that the Contrast rule can affect ellipsis licensing.

However, the SQA_{CUE}'s prediction that the clause-type of the antecedent should affect acceptability was not borne out. How should this be explained? Retreating to the basic in-situ approach would be misguided, as this approach makes the incorrect prediction that modulating ADJECTIVE (i.e., *bare* versus *marked*) should not affect judgments. Our tentative solution to this puzzle is to suggest that Experiment 4 contains a hitherto unnoticed confound that renders it unable to adequately test the SQA_{CUE}'s claims about the effect on acceptability of varying the clause-type of the antecedent. Specifically, we propose that the SQA cannot be properly tested by comparing declarative assertoric to polar question antecedents (as Experiment 4 did), because the true licenser for the fragmentary response in a dialogue such as (60) (repeated below in (61)) is not actually the polar question itself, but the implicit *wh*-question raised after answering the polar question with *yes* or *no* (see (62)). If this is correct, then the SQA would actually predict that non-*wh* fragments that immediately follow a declarative assertion **or** a polar question display the same properties, as both have implicit *wh*-question licensers and therefore both should display the hallmarks of A'-moved phrases. (For the reasoning behind this, recall §2.1 and see Griffiths 2019, Griffiths et al. 2023.)

(61) A: Ist das eine groß-e Höhle?
is that a-FEM big-FEM cave
'Is that a big cave?'

B: Nein, klein-e.
no small-FEM
'No, small.'

(62) A: Did John eat an apple?	<i>A utters a polar question</i>
B: No <John didn't eat an apple>, [what did John eat, then?] <John ate> a banana.	<i>B answers with a polarity fragment</i> <i>B's 'no' answer raises an implicit wh-question</i> <i>B's non-wh fragment is licensed from the implicit wh-question</i>

If this critical assessment is correct, then the SQA_{CUE} can only be properly tested by comparing dialogues in which fragments are preceded by either declarative assertion, a *wh*-question or a polar question to dialogues in which fragments are preceded by an alternative question, as only in the latter type of dialogue is the fragment not licensed by an explicit or implicit

¹⁴ Considering that Experiments 3 and 4 were identical aside from their test stimuli and their participant sample (the same fillers, test stimuli of the same length and complexity), it seems implausible to us to claim that this discrepancy is an experimental artifact.

wh-question. Put differently, it might be the case that Experiment 4 – and, by extension, Experiment 2 – were inadequately designed to properly test the SQA_{CUE} , and that an adequately designed experiment would compare dialogues such as those as (59) to those in (63). However, due to resource constraints, we must leave this comparison for future research.¹⁵

- (63) A: Ist das eine groß-e oder klein-e Höhle?
 is that a-FEM big-FEM or small-FEM cave
 ‘Is that a big or small cave?’
 B: Klein. / Klein-e.
 small small-FEM

8. Comparison with Schiele 2026

We mentioned in §2.4 that our experiments on German adjectival fragments partly replicate experiments reported in Griffiths & Schiele 2025 and Schiele 2025, 2026 (we henceforth take Schiele 2026 as representative of this work). Figure 5 presents a comparison of our results and Schiele’s. Regarding the experiments on *wh*-fragments, our experiment replicates the significant effect that Schiele reports for ADJECTIVE (i.e., whether the *wh*-remnant is bare or declined) and, by adding the factor ELLIPSIS (*ellipsis* or *no ellipsis*), our partial replication experiment contributes the novel finding that responding with a declined *wh*-adjective fragment degrades acceptability to the same extent that island-violating LBE does in non-elliptical configurations, which provides the first direct evidence that declined *wh*-adjectival fragments are derived from an elliptical clause in which LBE occurs.

Regarding the experiments on non-*wh* fragments, our experiment added to Schiele’s the factor ANTECEDENT, meaning that, unlike Schiele’s experiment, ours could (attempt to) adjudicate between different in-situ theories of clausal ellipsis. Because Schiele’s experiment on non-*wh* fragments focused on dialogues in which the antecedent was a declarative assertion, the right panel in Figure 5 compares to her results only a subset of our results from Experiment 4, namely, the *declarative antecedent* subset. One observes that our experiment replicates the contrast Schiele reports for the *presentational* condition (ours more clearly), yet our results and hers differ for the *contrastive* condition.

We speculate that this difference can be traced to a difference in stimuli-design. In our stimuli, the antecedent utterance was always copular-clausal (see (64), repeated from (59)), whereas Schiele’s test items employed antecedents with full, lexical verbs (65) (Schiele 2026).

- (64) A: Das ist eine groß-e Höhle.
 That is a-FEM big-FEM cave
 ‘That’s a big cave.’
 a. B: Nein, klein.
 no small
 b. B: Nein, klein-e.
 no small-FEM
- (65) A: Das neue Gesetz wird vor allem reich-en Bürgern zugutekommen.
 The new law will above all rich-ACC citizens benefit

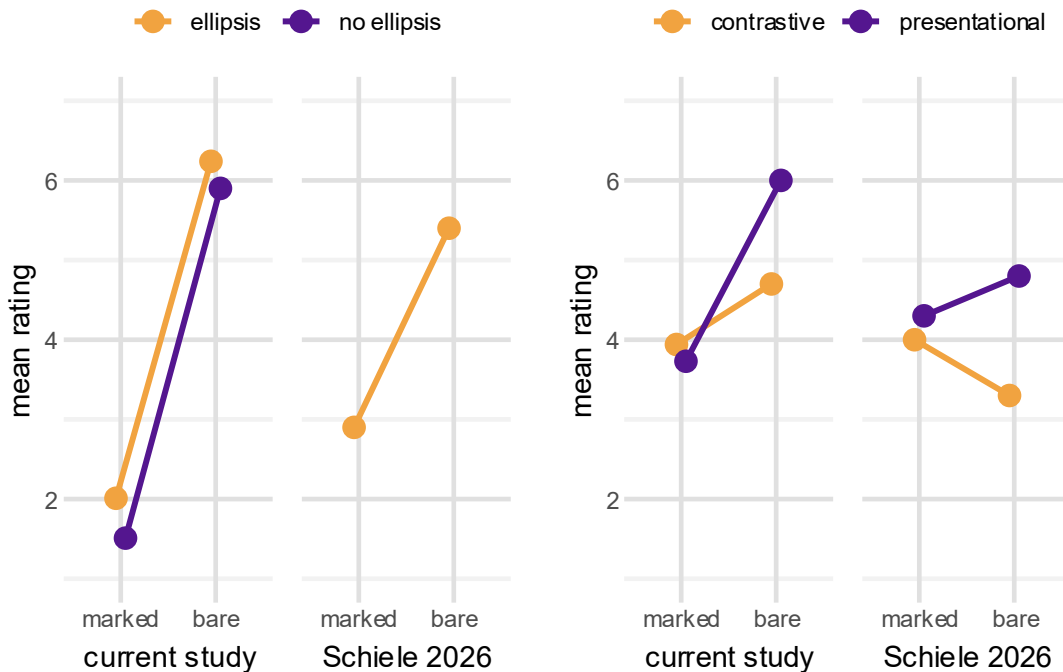
¹⁵ In order to obtain a tentative impression, we asked 13 native-German-speaking linguists whether the declined version of (63B) is more natural than (61B). 7 answered affirmatively. We also asked whether the declined version of (63B) is natural in absolute terms, and only 2 answered affirmatively. The unclarity of these initial results demonstrates clearly that a large-scale experiment is required to make any genuine progress on this issue.

‘The new law will mostly benefit rich citizens.’

- a. B: Nein, arm.
No poor.
- b. B: Nein, arm-en.
No poor-ACC

In (64), the discursive connection between A’s utterance and the fragmentary correction in (64a) is straightforward: (64a) is merely a corrective paraphrase of (64A) (i.e., *no, (the cave is) small*). However, the discourse connection between (65A) and (65a) is less straightforward, as (65a) is a supplementary correction about the rich citizens, rather than a correction of the entire antecedent. Seeing as clausal ellipsis is extremely sensitive to the discursive relation that obtains between an elliptical clause and its antecedent (Griffiths 2026), we speculate that the effort required to process the less straightforward discourse relation between (65A) and (65a) is reflected in lowered acceptability ratings. We propose that this processing difficulty, when compounded by the fact that contrast forces an isomorphic elliptical clause with which the morphologically bare fragment in (65a) is incompatible, drags mean ratings for the [*contrastive, marked*] condition down lower than the mean ratings for the [*contrastive, bare*] condition in Schiele’s results. In short, we propose that, by using dialogues containing copular-clausal antecedents, as our experiment did, our experiment provides a more accurate representation of how the factors of interest (namely, ADJECTIVE and FOCUS) negatively affect judgments, as such dialogue are free from extraneous confounds related to discourse relations.¹⁶

Figure 5. A comparison of our experiments and those reported in Schiele 2026, submitted. Left panel = *wh*-fragments (Exp 3); right panel = non *wh*-fragments with a declarative antecedent (a subset of Exp 4)



¹⁶ Note that our claim is testable: if one were to re-run the English experiments reported in §§4–5 but use antecedents with full, lexical verbs rather than copular-clausal antecedents, then we expect increased degradation in acceptability for those test items in the contrastive condition.

9. General discussion and conclusion

The results of the German experiments reported in §§6–7 strongly support the view that the LBC is not obviated by clausal ellipsis, and that the LBC can be evaded when an anisomorphic ellipsis site that does not contain an island is available. Because the negative effect size for declined adjectival fragments differs according to whether the fragment is a *wh*-phrase or a non-*wh* phrase, these results also disfavour a move-and-delete island evasion analysis, which treats all types of remnants as undergoing A'-movement and therefore incorrectly predicts that all marked adjectival fragments should incur an island-penalty of the same size. Therefore, an in-situ approach is favoured. However, a basic in-situ approach – namely, one that predicts that *marked* non-*wh* adjectival fragments are fully acceptable – is insufficient. Instead, an in-situ approach is required that predicts **some** degree of degradation for marked non-*wh* adjectival fragments. The SQA fits this description, as the SQA states that *marked* non-*wh* adjectival fragments are degraded for pragmatic rather than syntactic reasons, namely because no *wh*-interrogative licenser can be accommodated to license ellipsis.

Although the English experiments reported in §§4–5 returned null results, it seems unlikely that these experiments were underpowered, as previous experiments on locality effects under ellipsis with similar sample sizes found significant contrasts. Therefore, we have interpreted these results as informative in several ways. First, they are incompatible with each of the move-and-delete analyses investigated in this paper, as these analyses predict that significant contrasts would be observed. Second, when coupled with the results from the German experiment, they suggest that the morphosyntactic composition of the remnant plays a crucial role in determining how the ellipsis site is recovered. Specifically, they suggest that there are two mechanisms for recovering ellipsis, one which compares the meanings of ellipsis site to the meaning of its licenser in the proximate discourse, and one which compares the syntactic structure of ellipsis site to the syntactic structure of the licenser. We have framed this in SQA-terms: the semantic strategy involves comparing the meaning of the ellipsis site to the maxQUD (with ellipsis being licensed if a Q-A congruence relation obtains between them), whereas the syntactic strategy involves comparing the structure of the ellipsis to the structure of an explicitly uttered or accommodated interrogative (with ellipsis being licensed if a syntactic matching condition, such as Anand et al.'s (2025), is satisfied). We claim that the syntactic strategy must be used if the remnant ellipsis displays a morphosyntactic cue that betrays its syntactic position in the elliptical clause. Such cues include case and agreement marking. Because this idea is inspired by independent psycholinguistic results that show that the retrieval of ellipsis sites proceeds via a cue-based search, we have referred to our augmented analysis as the 'cue-based retrieval' version of the SQA (SQA_{CUE}).

As mentioned already in §2.3, our conceptual operationalization of cue-based retrieval differs substantially from its deployment elsewhere. For instance, Nykiel et al. (2022) appeal to cue-based retrieval to explain why, in many languages, there is a preference or even an obligation for remnants to match in morphological case with their antecedents. The experimental results reported in §§6–7 demonstrate that, at least in German, no such preference obtains for declined adjectives. In fact, the opposite obtains: *ceteris paribus*, bare adjectival fragments are judged as more acceptable than their declined counterparts even when their correlates are declined. Generally speaking, a nonsententialist analysis such as Nykiel et al.'s (2022), even when supplemented with constraints engendered by cue-based retrieval preferences/requirements, is likely to struggle to accommodate the results from §§6–7, as these results are straightforwardly explained by appealing to island effects under clausal ellipsis, to which nonsententialist analyses can make no recourse.

It should be emphasized that the conclusions that we have reached in this paper, some of which are rather unconventional, must be subject to further experimental investigation. In particular, our claim about the superiority of the SQA_{CUE} requires confirmation by determining whether dialogues in which the antecedent is an alternative question provides the amelioration effects that the SQA_{CUE} predicts. Beyond this, additional crosslinguistic comparisons of morphologically rich and morphologically poor languages are required to determine whether the cue-based retrieval process functions as we suggest. In addition, if island-violating movement is indeed responsible for the negative effect on acceptability observed in Experiment 3, then the prediction arises that declined adjectival *wh*-fragments should be fully acceptable in languages in which the left-branch extraction of APs is grammatical. For an experimental investigation into the acceptability of adjectival fragments in Turkish, which is a language that (arguably) permits left-branch extraction of APs (Bošković & Şener 2014) but sadly does not decline its adjectives, see Griffiths & Çiçek (2025) and Çiçek & Griffiths (in prep).

Data Availability

All experimental stimuli are available on request.

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